

That immediacy feels resonant as India strengthens its presence on the cultural stage. With NMACC bringing large-scale international productions to Mumbai, audiences can finally experience world-class musical theatre at home. "India is already a major global hub for film," Stefaniuk says. "To see the country investing in world-class theatre spaces like this and welcoming global productions is tremendously exciting. It is a natural evolution."

More than two decades on, *Wicked* continues to defy gravity. In Mumbai, it does so anew, not as a travelling replica but as a freshly imagined production that honours its legacy while speaking powerfully to the present moment. ■

—Nikhil Sardana

Wicked The Musical
debuts at the Grand Theatre at NMACC, Mar. 12-29

THEATRE ▼

WOMEN IN **FOCUS**

The upcoming* Mahindra Excellence in Theatre Awards theatre festival *promises a diverse line-up of plays

Once again, 10 outstanding plays have been shortlisted for the Mahindra Excellence in Theatre Awards (META), which returns to Delhi from March 19 to 25. For its 21st edition, a record-breaking 422 submissions were received in 60 languages and dialects from 20 states.

"The 10 plays chosen span multiple languages, forms and perspectives, highlighting the extraordinary creativity of theatre-makers," says Sanjoy K. Roy, managing director, Teamwork Arts. Interestingly, five out of the 10 nominated plays have women-centric themes. "These stories reaffirm the importance of creating space for women's voices in our cultural conversations," adds Jay Shah, vice president, and head, Cultural Outreach, Mahindra Group.

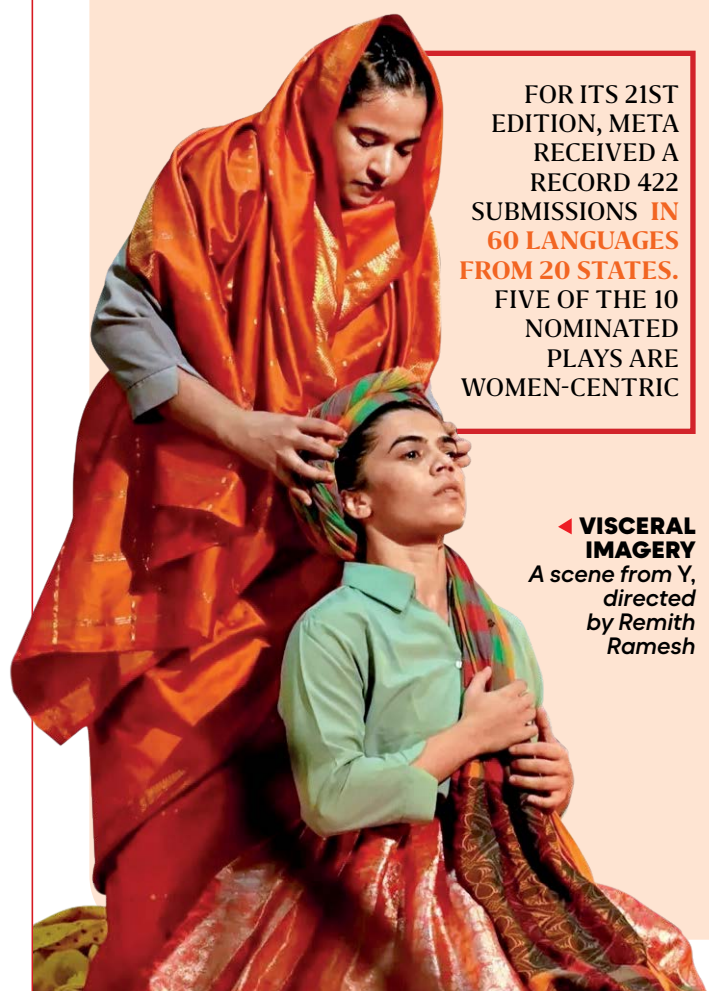
Ambaa, directed by Atul Kumar, is an interpretation of the 4th century BC Greek comedy *Lysisterata*. Under Ambaa's leadership, all the women of the country resolve to end a war by denying their spouses sexual pleasure until the fighting stops. *Dhomi Kitha Kitha Dhomi*, directed by O.T. Shajahan, centres on Ramayana's formidable Shoorpanakha. *Kadambari*, directed by Meghna Roy Choudhury, is a theatrical journey into the silenced life of Kadambari Devi, Rabindranath Tagore's critic, muse and sister-in-law. *Karunashtake*, directed by Prajakt Deshmukh, is a poetic meditation on womanhood, widowhood and the silences imposed upon both. *Something Like Truth*, directed by Parna Pethe and written by Shanta Gokhale, offers a glimpse into the experiences of women navigating structures of power and silence.

Purva Naresh-directed *Chandni Raatein* is a love story that spans four nights. *Je Janlagulor Akash Chilo*, directed by Saurav Palodhi, has four friends from the 1990s losing their childhood in the compulsion to grow up. Directed by Ajeet Singh Pallawat, *Mithyasur* explores the deep influence of myths in the evolution of civilisation. Under Neeraj G.M.'s direction, *The Old Man and the Sea—Kathakali of Morrow* intertwines Kathakali with the classic narrative of survival and resilience. *Y*, directed by Remith Ramesh, unfolds as a series of potent, visceral images where relationships become tension, and home becomes a breath too tight to hold. ■

—Neha Kirpal

META Theatre Festival will be held in Delhi, Mar. 19-25

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◀ VISCERAL IMAGERY
A scene from Y, *directed by Remith Ramesh*